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ASSIGNMENT: REPORT WRITING

TITLE: WORKPLACE STRESS IN HEALTHCARE INDUSTRY

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1.0 Introduction, Purpose and Objective - Afiq Danial

1.1 General Background - Afiq Danial

Stress in the workplace in healthcare is a growing issue where the professionals or workers are often exposed to a high pressure environment, emotional exhaustion and time sensitive decisions that make a huge impact towards the people's health. Healthcare workers also can suffer from occupational stress as a result of lack of skills, organisational factors, and low social support at work (Ruotsalainen et al., 2023). Their psychological health may tend to drop due to the importance of keeping the professionalism of patients' expectation and satisfaction. These factors contribute a crucial part to the stress level among healthcare workers that can lead to feeling burnout, fatigue and even psychological disorder. Patient-care professionals or healthcare givers experience higher levels of mental stress compared to other workers (Khasawneh et al., 2021).

1.2 Rationale - Afiq Danial

Stress in the healthcare industry continues to be a persistent and frequently disregarded issue, despite growing awareness of the problem. Both professionals and workers continue to work under the pressure, with increased emotional demands and critical and also responsibility for timely sensitivities that have directly affected patients' lives. These stress effectors frequently become worse due to organisational flaws, low quality support systems and insufficient training. Although the mental health of this organisation's workers is important to ensure the quality care and fulfill patients' satisfaction, most of them neglected their working policies and practices in the workplace. The lack of concern to address psychological distress and burnout not only has huge significant implications to their own well being but also the overall performance and safety of healthcare delivery. Therefore, it is crucial to highlight and address this whole issue to get the evidence of the healthcare worker's stress across the globe.

2.0 Background of the Problem

2.1 Patient Care Expectations - Afiq Danial

Medical professionals are always expected to be thorough and caring, regardless of the situation. Khasawneh et al. (2021) state that healthcare providers are responsible for delivering high-quality, safe, timely, and equitable services to patients. These expectations include managing complex treatments, providing emotional support, and responding to urgent situations such as a patient's death or a sudden deterioration in their condition. For instance, some professionals in the surgical department have confessed that one of the most difficult and heartbreaking tasks is informing families about the death of a loved one. In addition, healthcare workers often face challenges in dealing with a wide range of patient behaviours. While some patients may be cooperative, others may not. This is especially common in psychiatric wards or emergency rooms, where patients suffering from severe trauma, anxiety, or mental health disorders may become uncooperative or even hostile, making communication and treatment more difficult. Despite these challenges, healthcare professionals are still expected to maintain professionalism and deliver appropriate care, which can be both mentally and emotionally exhausting over time.

2.2 Long Working Hours and Sleep Deprivation - Iman Abadi

Long working hours are synonymous among healthcare workers, as the nature of their work requires extended hours compared to professionals in other fields and is considered extremely demanding. According to Lin et al. (2021), healthcare workers suffer from stress and burnout from the lack of sleep time available to them. Sleep helps the body and brain rest, improving bodily functions necessary for daily activities. Developing a clinically diagnosed burnout by people who sleep less than 6 hours is well-documented, as sleep is essential for the body's autonomic response and energy restoration (Lin et al. 2021). Depriving the body of rest can be detrimental to workers' health because when they do not get enough sleep, their health condition worsens as they are forced to work overtime with each passing day. This in turn creates a loop where they are constantly in a state of exhaustion. Bondagji et al. (2022) stated that lack of rest among workers can have an impact on the quality of their work, resulting in poor performance and concentration, decreasing the quality of patient care, or even increasing the

chance of medical errors. From this, long working hours can affect not only the workers health but also put the patients health at risk.

2.3 Insufficient Staffing - Alif Fathi

Staffing shortage is one of the major problems leading to stress in the healthcare industry. This problem is usually caused by high turnover of existing staff. The literature published from January 2020 to February 2023 was analysed in a meta-analysis, which demonstrated that the global nurse turnover rate was 16% (Ren et al. 2024). Because of this high turnover, the current nurses are forced to take on more work to make up for the staffing shortage. According to Galoustian (2023), a survey conducted in collaboration with FAU's Christine E. Lynn College of Nursing found that more than half of nurses identified insufficient staffing as the most negative aspect of their job. Under such conditions, nurses are usually required to work longer hours, take on multiple roles, and sacrifice breaks to meet the demands of their job. This increased workload not only contributes to feelings of being overworked but also increasing frustration, eventually worsening staff motivation and possibly increasing the risk of further turnover.

3.0 Possible Solution

3.1 Flexible Schedules - Salman

Stress can be reduced by enhancing the work environment. The demands of the healthcare work practice include long working hours, great emotional load, and unstable schedules, which provoke the development of fatigue, psychological pressure, and low job satisfaction. Howard and Houry (2024) proposed to implement such strategic measures as offering flexible schedules for healthcare sector employees. With flexibly planned systems of scheduling, such as switch of shifts, part-time work, staggered hours, and compressed hours, medical organizations enable employees to balance individual commitments, family requirements, and time off. These arrangements stimulate the preservation of physiologic and psychological well-being, increase focus, strengthen motivational abilities, and increase empathetic care. In turn, flexibility in health services enables a more sustainable workforce, staff retention, and better therapeutic outcomes.

3.2 Wearable Biosensors and Real-Time Stress Monitoring - Mukhritz

Technology provides new instruments to identify and manage stress at an early stage. Wearable biosensors that track such physiological markers as heart rate variability can be used to detect the indications of increasing stress levels in real-time, as Williams and Lewis (2024) suggest. Healthcare institutions can use this data to curb the problem of stress before it escalates to burnout by incorporating the data into the healthcare operations. It is possible to make the support personal by checking in with the employee regularly, sending alerts when needed, and scheduling smartly using the gathered data. Moreover, data analytics and individual reporting channels can assist the leadership in recognizing patterns and systemic problems that lead to work-related stress. Since biosensors are experimentally proven to accurately identify stress and prevent workers from experiencing burnout or depression at work, they are recommended to be widely adopted in the healthcare industry.

4.0 Conclusion and Recommendations - Iman Abadi

The increasing incidence of burnout and stress among medical workers is caused by high expectations for patient care, long work hours, and understaffing. These issues not only have an impact on workers' well-being, but they also affect the quality and safety of healthcare practice. However, offering flexible working hours enables the healthcare worker to have a better work-life balance, as it helps with both mental and physical health. Moreover, using wearable biosensors and real-time stress monitoring helps spot early signs of stress and burnout while also providing necessary data to identify the root cause of work-related stress. Therefore, having a work environment that prioritizes healthcare workers' well-being is essential for hospitals to offer high standards of patient care.

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6.0 Appendix

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